

Section 8 Landlord Starter Checklist

Everything you need to register with your PHA, pass your first HCV inspection, and place your first guaranteed-rent tenant.

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STEP 1 — REGISTER WITH YOUR LOCAL PHA

- ☐ **Find your local Public Housing Authority (PHA)**
Search HUD.gov/program_offices/public_indian_housing/programs/hcv/ ! click "PHA Contact Info"
- ☐ **Submit a landlord / property owner application**
Most PHAs have an online form; some require an in-person visit
- ☐ **Provide proof of property ownership**
Deed, mortgage statement, or county assessor record
- ☐ **Provide proof of property insurance**
Current homeowners or landlord policy — minimum coverage required by PHA
- ☐ **Pass initial property eligibility check**
Property must meet HQS / NSPIRE standards before a voucher holder can move in
- ☐ **Set up direct deposit for HAP payments**
PHA pays the housing assistance portion directly to you each month

STEP 2 — PREPARE FOR THE HCV INSPECTION (NSPIRE STANDARDS)

- ☐ **Smoke detectors on every floor + in every bedroom**
Must be working — inspector will test them
- ☐ **Carbon monoxide detectors on every sleeping floor**
- ☐ **All windows open, lock, and close properly**
Broken sash cords, cracked glass, or painted-shut windows = fail
- ☐ **All doors open, close, and lock properly**
Includes exterior doors, interior bedroom doors, and bathroom doors
- ☐ **No peeling paint anywhere (interior or exterior)**
Pre-1978 properties: lead paint disclosure required
- ☐ **Hot and cold running water at all fixtures**
Check under sinks for leaks — inspectors look under cabinets
- ☐ **Water heater properly installed with T&P relief valve**
Discharge pipe must run to within 6" of floor
- ☐ **HVAC / heating system in working order**
Must be able to maintain 68°F in all habitable rooms
- ☐ **No exposed electrical wiring or open junction boxes**



GFCI outlets in kitchen, bathrooms, and exterior locations



No evidence of pest infestation (roaches, rodents)

If found: exterminate and re-inspect before approval

All appliances included in the lease are working

Stove, refrigerator — confirm with your PHA which are required

STEP 3 — PLACE YOUR FIRST GUARANTEED-RENT TENANT

Accept Housing Choice Voucher (HCV) application

Ask applicant for their voucher and verify it is current and valid

Verify unit size matches voucher bedroom size

PHA will not approve a 3BR voucher in a 2BR unit

Confirm your rent does not exceed the PHA payment standard

Check Fair Market Rent at huduser.gov/portal/datasets/fmr.html

Complete the Request for Tenancy Approval (RFTA)

You and the tenant sign this together — submit to PHA to start the process

Schedule and pass the HCV inspection

PHA inspector visits the unit — use the Step 2 checklist to prep

Sign the Housing Assistance Payment (HAP) contract with PHA

This is your government contract — PHA pays you directly each month

Execute your standard lease with the tenant

Lease term, tenant responsibilities, rules — same as any rental

Collect security deposit from tenant

Tenant pays security deposit; PHA pays the housing assistance portion of rent

Document move-in condition with photos/video

Date-stamped photos of every room — protects your deposit claim at move-out

KEY RESOURCES

Find your PHA: hud.gov/program_offices/public_indian_housing/programs/hcv

Fair Market Rents: huduser.gov/portal/datasets/fmr.html

This checklist is a starting point. PHA requirements vary by jurisdiction.

The full process — inspections, RFTA, HAP contracts, and payment standards — is covered inside the course.

